

SCENE 1: HOME

A modest living room. Evening. LINA (19) sits at the kitchen table doing homework. Her father HASSAN (52) enters, loosening his tie.

HASSAN: *(without looking at her)* Did you cook?

LINA: I just got home from school, Baba. I—

HASSAN: Your sister was cooking at your age. You're useless.

Her brother KARIM (24) walks in, throws his jacket on the couch.

KARIM: She was out all day "studying." *(mocking air quotes)* Like that'll get her anywhere.

LINA: *(quietly)* I have exams next week.

KARIM: Nobody cares, Lina. Make tea at least.

Lina stands slowly, eyes down. Her older sister SARA (26) enters from the hallway, still in her work clothes. She clocks the scene immediately.

SARA: *(firm, calm)* She's not making tea. I'll make it. Lina, sit down.

KARIM: Don't start, Sara—

SARA: I said sit down, Lina. *(to Karim)* You have two hands. Use them.

Silence. Hassan opens his newspaper. Karim mutters and walks away. Sara goes to the kitchen, then leans in to whisper to Lina.

SARA: *(low)* You study. I've got this. Don't let them shrink you.

Lina looks up — the first time all scene. A small, fragile smile.

SCENE 2: THE BAR

A dimly lit bar. Music thumps low. LINA sits at a table with her boyfriend ADAM (22), laughing, relaxed — a rare version of herself.

ADAM: You look happy tonight.

LINA: I am. For once.

Three girls — RANYA, DOUNIA, IMANE — approach. They know Adam. Ranya slides into the seat next to him too comfortably.

RANYA: *(ignoring Lina)* Adam! You didn't say you'd be here.

ADAM: *(awkward)* Hey... yeah, just a quiet night.

DOUNIA: *(eyeing Lina up and down)* And who's this?

ADAM: This is Lina. My girlfriend.

The girls exchange a look — the kind that carries a whole conversation.

IMANE: *(sweetly)* Oh. Cute. She looks... young.

LINA: I'm nineteen.

RANYA: *(to Adam, ignoring Lina again)* Remember that night at Sami's place? *(laughs)* Good times.

LINA: *(to Adam, quietly)* Do you want me to leave?

ADAM: No. Hey — *(to the girls)* we were in the middle of something.

RANYA: *(standing, smiling at Lina with ice behind it)* No worries. We'll be right over there. *(to Adam)* Come find us later.

They leave. Lina stares at her glass.

ADAM: Ignore them.

LINA: Who are they?

ADAM: Old crowd. They're nobody.

LINA: They didn't treat me like I was nobody. They treated me like I was nothing.

A beat. Adam reaches for her hand. She lets him — but something has shifted behind her eyes.

SCENE 3: WORK

Split setting — two moments.

— PART A: The Restaurant —

A busy kitchen. Lina rushes between tables in a uniform two sizes too big. Her manager MR. FARES (45) watches her like a hawk.

MR. FARES: Table six has been waiting twelve minutes.

LINA: I had three tables at once, the order system froze—

MR. FARES: I don't want excuses. A customer complained about your attitude.

LINA: My— I didn't do anything wrong.

MR. FARES: You argued with him about the bill.

LINA: He was wrong about the bill.

MR. FARES: *(leaning in)* The customer is never wrong. You're done. Turn in your apron.

LINA: You're firing me? Over this?

MR. FARES: End of shift. Don't come back.

Lina unties her apron slowly. She doesn't cry. She walks out through the back door into the alley, leans against the wall, and breathes.